

HP Deskjet D4168

The Twin-Tank Wonder

HP has a winner here, at least in the looks department. A sleek yet long printer, the D4168 is, visually, a stunner. Some may find the permanently-affixed tray an eyesore, particularly since it protrudes upwards—but it does blend in well at the base.

The same shiny white cover that looks appealing on the D2360 exudes a touch of class here. The D4168 proudly wears HP's "Vivera Inks" Badge, which *should* translate to better photo quality.

HP once again deviates from the myth that photo printers must have individual tanks. The D4168 has just two cartridges! The printer offers PictBridge support, but this is more a necessity than a bonus feature nowadays. The bulky power adapter rears its ugly self again here, and is a real irritant.

The drivers are excellent, and you can create multiple profiles with finely-tuned settings for each type of printing job—mono-



chrome, text/image, photo printing, etc.

The Deskjet 4168 is a good performer for its price—Rs 3,999. Text documents were printed clear and crisp, with no visual anomalies or aliasing of any sort. In fact, even at fast draft settings, the D4168 is one good text document printer, which is the way it should be, in our humble opinion!

Our combination document did have a few issues. Most noticeable was the fact that the 4168 failed to print the embedded photograph well. The line aliasing was absent (a good sign), however, the text readability at 2-point size wasn't as good as the Canon Pixmas' offerings. The same goes for the reverse colour test, where

the text wasn't readable once the font size became tiny.

The photograph test was handled well, with superb specular effects and some great neutral colour tones throughout the printout. Detailing was very good, as was the texture effect, especially the grainy feel of the leather bag and the dimpling on the golf balls.

In fact, all the printers missed out on the dimpling which, while not immediately noticeable, does become apparent when you scrutinise the printout for a while. Unfortunately, the D4168 had some issues with the facial printouts, where there seemed to be a lack of dpi, and fine white grains (unprinted parts of paper) were visible where there should have been none.

All in all, a great deal for the price. If you want something for printing superb text printouts as well as something that'll be able to give you some great photo memories on a budget, the Deskjet 4168 is the way to go.

HP Photosmart A516

The tiniest printer we've seen!

HP's Photosmart A516 is the smallest printer we've ever received for a test, period. Smaller even than their Deskjet 460B which we tested last year! The major difference was, this isn't an A4 printer. Instead, HP touts the A516 as an ultra-compact 4x6 photo printer.

Build quality is right up there with the best, and despite its diminutive dimensions, the A516 feels extremely sturdy to hold. Quality of both the doors (which serve as the in and out trays) is very good.

The body is finished in the piano-white we've come to love, with an off-white matte-finished strip on the top and down the sides. The top of the printer is adorned with five soft buttons, including a tiny "print cancel" button—something we missed on a lot of the big printers.

Interfacing doesn't require a PC, and is done via a 1.5-inch LCD screen that's sufficiently sharp to ensure you can see what you're printing easily. Naturally, PictBridge is present, which is mandatory on such a printer. Also concealed under the paper-out flap are the memory-card-reader slots. There are individual slots for CF, SD, and MS cards, while SM and xD type memory cards share a slot.

Despite the fact that the A516 is reasonably operable without a PC nearby, HP has provided a complete



driver set, easily on par with their excellent drivers on the Deskjet 4168. Once again, all the settings you'll be using are available on a single page, and yet it doesn't seem cluttered. Paper options are obviously limited here, due to the size of the printer, of course, and a few printing options available on the other HP drivers are also missing.

Because of its non-A4 nature, we didn't pit this little printer against the bigger boys, however capable it may have seemed to the task. What we did was fire up a couple of photo prints including our test sheets, which we scaled down to an appropriate size. Printing photographs is what the A516 is all about (whoever heard of text documents on 4x6 media?), and the A516 uses a single cartridge to achieve this!

To its credit, print quality was good, though our test photo at once seemed to lack that vivid look. The photo had very good detailing, however, and finer details were visible. Highlighting and specular effects were reproduced well.

Overall, HP's A516 is a very capable little photo printer that you can carry around in a rather large pocket. At Rs 5,499, the A516 is clearly aimed at the segment of users that wants photo-quality 4x6 prints, anywhere, anytime.

Now, all you need to have to get great 4x6 prints is a spare power outlet!